NewsBank inc.

No protests at UC Berkeley vigil - Victims saluted with songs, poetry, tears, impassioned speeches

September 12, 2002 | Oakland Tribune, The (CA)
Author: William Brand, STAFF WRITER | Section: Headline News | 500 Words
OpenURL Link

BERKELEY -- Nine-eleven plus one was an unusual day at the University of California, Berkeley. It was a day without protest.

Without a word of dissent or a single jeer, students on Sproul Plaza saluted the victims of the Sept. 11 terrorist attack with songs, poetry, tears and impassioned speeches. Students passed out white roses and red, white and blue ribbons. Money was collected for families of the Sept. 11 victims.

The day ended with an open microphone on Sproul Plaza and a candlelight vigil.

"UC Berkeley has a proud history of political activism," said Associated Students President Jesse Gabriel. "But today is not about politics. It's about realizing that change will begin when each person realizes he or she can make a difference."

Dressed in black and carrying a small American flag, UC Berkeley Chancellor Robert Berdahl spoke briefly. "People of all races and of every religion were murdered on that day, and like each of us they were people with hopes and dreams and plans for their lives," Berdahl said.

"We mourn for our world and we know the attack ... has unleashed the blood tide of war and that everywhere innocence is drowned," he said, reminding students that patriotism is not measured by how often we fly the flag.

"The true measure is how well we preserve the liberties of the republic for which that flag stands," he said.

Throughout the day, members of the university community scrawled emotional messages on huge swathes of red, white and blue butcher paper on Sproul Plaza.

"Peace, not war, does not mean we are not Americans," one wrote.

"In loving memory of Jose Nava, father, husband, friend, member of the Port Authority. 9.11.01" was written beside a bouquet of flowers.

But in Berkeley, politics is never far away. Someone else scrawled, "Sept. 11, 1973 -- U.S. led-coup in Chile kills 30,000."

At noon, the Campanile bells began to toll the hour. On Sproul Plaza someone yelled "Quiet," and a hush fell over the campus.

The only sound was a siren in the distance. A crowd estimated at 1,500 to 2,000 stood quietly. Even the almost constant flow of students and faculty members to classes stopped.

As the silence ended, John Lennon's "Imagine" played on the loudspeakers. Then a dozen student speakers delivered eulogies and two Muslim students read a selection from the Koran, Surah, Chapter 49, Verse 13.

There were a handful of protest signs, but their message was mild. "Peace is patriotic," one said.

The day at UC Berkeley began with a prayer circle of remembrance on Sproul Plaza at 9 a.m. Sponsored by the

University Religious Council, about 30 people, including Protestant ministers, a priest, a rabbi and a Muslim iman, read and prayed.

Nearby, Mary Boktor, a student senator of Arab descent, and Will Youmans of the campus Arab Student Association, urged the public to remember that not everyone who died in the Sept. 11 maelstrom was American.

Remember the innocents in Afghanistan who also died as a result of Sept. 11, the farmers and the people at a wedding party, killed by American forces, Youmans said.

(c) 2002 The Oakland Tribune. All rights reserved. Reproduced with the permission of Media NewsGroup, Inc. by NewsBank, Inc.

- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Brand, W. (2002, September 12). No protests at UC Berkeley vigil - Victims saluted with songs, poetry, tears, impassioned speeches. *Oakland Tribune, The (CA).* Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/0F993687C77FCFFF.